reassure the Sikkimese, Haksar also suggested a critical reappraisal of India-Sikkim relations.[42]

The Gandhi government even made an attempt toward rapprochement with Pakistan. It did this directly and through Soviet officials,[43] who had been urging an India-Pakistan rapprochement so they could "jointly tackle China."[44] But Gandhi found the response "very disappointing."[45]

India also continued to look to Moscow for implicit and explicit security assistance against China. Despite supply hiccups, the Soviet Union remained India's main military supplier.[46] Officials reiterated their concern about China's "unabated malevolence" toward India to their Soviet counterparts, and that its "attack" on the Soviet Union had only created a "new bond" between Delhi and Moscow. Kosygin, in turn, declared to Gandhi that the other nuclear powers would not allow the use of nuclear weapons against India.[47] Soviet defense minister Marshal Andrei Grechko assured Indian officials that if China attacked India, the Soviet Union would provide assistance.[48]

Moscow also suggested to Delhi that the two countries sign a treaty. In March 1969, Soviet ambassador Nikolai Pegov sold the treaty as "very good insurance against any possible aggression by China or Pakistan."[49] The Soviet motivation, as Indian ambassador in Moscow Durga Prasad (D. P.) Dhar saw it, was deteriorating Sino-Soviet relations. Kosygin repeated the offer to Gandhi when they met in May and tried to sweeten the deal with economic incentives. Haksar was keen to act on the offer. Dhar, on his part, noted it would come with additional military equipment.[50] But Gandhi was reluctant because of the domestic and Chinese reaction. She worried that the treaty would be seen as a move away from nonalignment or "directed against a third party." Nonetheless, she agreed to "exploratory talks." Until that point, the elements discussed had been more akin to those in the Panchsheel treaty. When Kosygin brought up the idea of including political cooperation in the treaty, Gandhi reacted strongly. She objected even more vociferously to the idea of mutual assistance provisions, noting that that would make it "a military agreement."[51]

Haksar urged Gandhi to strike while the iron was hot. He asserted that India needed to take advantage of "Soviet anxiety" vis-à-vis China at the time. The situation could change "overnight" and Delhi could not take the Soviet relationship or Moscow's support for granted. India needed to